Growing persecution of Jewish people in Europe in the 1930s, particularly in territory controlled by Nazi Germany, led to an influx of Jewish settlers to Mandatory Palestine. These settlers began to apply pressure on the British administration to fulfill its pledge to create a Jewish homeland. Their pleas led to the creation of a British Royal Commission in 1936 that suggested partitioning Mandatory Palestine into two separate territories: one under the control of Arabs and one controlled by Jews. The Jewish leaders accepted this proposal, but Palestinian Arabs, with the support of neighboring Arab nations, absolutely opposed it. In the end, the commission came to nothing.

After the end of World War II in 1945, Britain remained in control of Mandatory Palestine. However, despite emerging knowledge of the Holocaust in Europe, the British refused to allow Jewish refugees to come to Palestine. In response, several armed Jewish resistance movements—including Haganah, Irgun, and Lehi—began a terrorist campaign in Palestine targeting British troops and facilities. This included the bombing of the King David Hotel in Jerusalem in the summer of 1946, an attack that left almost 100 people dead.

Exhausted by six years of war, Britain could no longer afford to station large numbers of troops in Mandatory Palestine. Britain approached the newly created United Nations and explained that, after its mandate in Palestine formally expired at midnight on May 14, 1948, it would no longer be able to control this territory. In November 1947, the UN announced a recommendation similar to that proposed in 1936: when the British mandate expired, Palestine should be partitioned into two separate territories, one Arab and one Jewish. Again, Jewish leaders happily accepted this recommendation, while the whole Arab world vehemently rejected it.

The clock was ticking. At midnight on May 14, 1948, all British forces would withdraw from Palestine. No one knew what would happen to the territory after that.